strongly worded letter to Ben-Gurion, in which he stated, “The US Government does not regard the present attitude of the Israeli Government as being consistent with the principles upon which US support has been based. The US Government is gravely concerned lest Israel now endanger the possibility of arriving at a solution of the Palestine problem in such a way as to contribute to the establishment of sound and friendly relations between Israel and its neighbors. . . . The Government of Israel must be aware that the attitude which it has thus far assumed at Lausanne must inevitably lead to a rupture in those conversations.”

In the 1956 Sinai Campaign, the Americans feared that the coalition of Britain, France, and Israel could lead the Soviets to intervene on behalf of Egypt, and that this in turn was liable to lead to a nuclear confrontation between the United States and the Soviet Union. This concern explains Eisenhower’s uncompromising position, which demanded that Ben-Gurion withdraw immediately from all of the territories it had conquered, down to the last centimeter (or inch).

Developments during the Sinai Campaign made it clear to Ben-Gurion that Britain and France were at best second-rate powers and that the final decision on any matter was in the hands of the United States. Therefore, throughout the government’s discussions on the withdrawal from Sinai, Ben-Gurion assigned Abba Eban, the Israeli ambassador to Washington and the UN, the responsibility for clarifying directly what America’s exact position was on all matters related to the subject.

At the end of the Six-Day War, Israel had the opportunity to take unilateral measures to find one solution or another to the refugee problem. It didn’t use this opportunity. As discussed above, Defense Minister Moshe Dayan, who steered Israeli policy on the territories occupied in the war, declared that Israel should focus on preserving the territories it had captured and that the other issues were trivial. This “sit and do nothing” policy, which left the issue of refugees in UNRWA’s hands, has remained unchanged to this day.

Toward the end of 2005, Israel gave in to heavy American pressure and agreed to hold general elections in the territories, although many claimed that these would lead to an unprecedented strengthening of Hamas. The elections were held in January 2006, and the warnings proved to be well founded. A year and a half later, in June 2007, Hamas took control of Gaza, systematically eliminating Fatah members in the Gaza Strip. Hamas